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Ignite Innovate Incubate

BIRAC

Energizing the Indian Innovation Ecosystem

To encourage, nurture and empower innovation and start-up ecosystem of India, Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC), a not-for-profit Public Sector Enterprise, was established in March 2012, under Department of Biotechnology, Government of India. BIRAC is aggressively transforming the landscape of innovation in biotechnology by building new pathways for an entrepreneurial journey through early-stage funding, incubation, product commercialization support and equity funding.

India is among the top 12 destinations for biotechnology in the world and holds a 3% share in the global biotechnology industry. India is currently ranked at 40th on the Global Innovation Index (GII). The biotechnology sector has witnessed exponential growth in recent decades. (as per the WIPO report 2023)

(REFERENCE: https://www.wipo.int/edocs/pubdocs/en/wipo-pub-2000-2023/in.pdf)

BIRAC has initiated several schemes, networks and platforms that have helped to bridge existing gaps in Biotech research and development and facilitates the development of novel, high-quality affordable products through cutting edge technologies. Carefully curated, BIRAC's schemes and programs cater to the entire gamut of innovations from ideation, proof of concept, validation, and commercialization by providing equity funding through three of its schemes i.e., SEED (Sustainable Entrepreneurship and Enterprise Development), LEAP (Launching Entrepreneurial Driven Affordable Products) and ACE (Accelerating Entrepreneurs). BIRAC funds a wide range of thematic areas including healthcare, agriculture, maternal and child health, nutrition, sanitation, waste to value, devices and diagnostics, bio-informatics, animal health, pharmaceuticals, energy, computing to name a few.

Under the concept laboratory-to-market, BIRAC, pro-actively handholds start-ups by providing financial and technical support and mentorship through strategically designed programs and schemes like BioNEST (Bioincubators Nurturing Entrepreneurship for Scaling Technologies), BIG (Biotechnology Ignition Grant), SITARE (Students Innovations for Translation & Advancement of Research Explorations), E-YUVA (Empowering Youth for Undertaking Value Added), SBIRI (Small Business Innovation Research Initiative), BIPP (Biotechnology Industry Partnership Programme), PACE (Promoting Academic Research Conversion to Enterprise), SIIP (Social Innovation Immersion Program), PATH (Patenting & Technology Transfer for Harnessing Innovations), and SPARSH (Social Innovation Programme for Products Affordable & Relevant to Societal Health).

Promoting "women entrepreneurship" in the country is a major initiative of BIRAC for boosting women entrepreneurship in biotechnology. Under the national annual **BIRAC-TiE WInER (Women in Entrepreneurial Research) Award** in partnership with TiE-Delhi NCR, so far 60 women entrepreneurs have been felicitated with a cash prize of Rs 5 lac. BIRAC's **Bioincubators for Women Entrepreneurs**, specifically supports women students/scientists/entrepreneurs, whereas 12 Women entrepreneurs have been supported under SPARSH (Social Innovation programme for products affordable and relevant to societal health).

Dr. Jitendra Kumar, Managing Director, BIRAC emphasized "*We are a tremendously growing economy in terms of innovation, ideas, and startups in the biotechnology sector. About 6000-7000 startups have been flourishing in the sector of Biotechnology and under the leadership of Hon'ble Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) Science & Technology; MoS PMO, Personnel, Public Grievances, Pensions, Atomic Energy and Space, Dr Jitendra Singh and with the guidance of Dr. Rajesh S. Gokhale, Secretary, Department of Biotechnology & Chairman BIRAC, this number will surely increase in the coming years.*"

Several start-ups funded by BIRAC have been working on major public health challenges to impact significantly the Indian biotechnology sector for instance the **Grand Challenges India** under the **DBT – BMGF partnership** for programs under Maternal & Child Health with women-centric focus such as Multi-Omics for Mothers & Infants Consortium (MOMI), and GARBH-Ini – (interdisciplinary Group for Advanced Research on Birth outcomes, - DBT India Initiative) recognized as Atal JaiAnusandhan Biotech Mission, being spearheaded by THSTI joined the Multi-Omics for Mothers and Infants (MOMI) Consortium. The **WINGS trial**, assessed the impact of an integrated package of evidence-based interventions i.e., health, nutrition, psychosocial, and WSH on nutritional and health outcomes for mothers and children. Data of over 3,80,000+ women and children have been utilized for such initiatives, which have become a global resource to answer critical questions pertaining to issues such as pre-term birth and other birth outcomes.

Under its **International and National Showcasing, Mentorship programs**, BIRAC has supported close to 350 women entrepreneurs and researchers across its various schemes such as BIG, SBIRI, BIPP, PACE etc., besides providing them with several showcasing opportunities at conferences such as IGNITE, UK Cambridge University; Lattitude59, Estonia; SLUSH, Finland; Global Bio-India; Boot camps with international faculty; FIRST Hub, New Delhi etc.

